If I Get Them, How Will I Financially Support Them: Challenges for Grandmother Caregivers

Naima Farah, McNair scholar, Department of Family Social Science • Priscilla A. Gibson, Ph. D., School of Social Work University of Minnesota

Purpose of Study

To examine the experiences of relative caregivers in accessing services mandated by social policies.

Introduction

•Kinship caregivers are relatives providing care to vulnerable young children whose parents are unable or unwilling to care for them (Leos-Urbel, Bess & Geen, 1999).
•Of the 2.7 million grandparents, 21% live in poverty (Child Welfare Information Gateway, 2010).
•Numerous social policies mandate placement preference and financial assistance to relatives.

Significance

•Kinship placement is associated with increasing social isolation and interfamily conflicts (Saunders, Hetling, Ovwigho & Born, 2012).
• Caregivers experience financial stress, and poor mental and emotional health (Williams & Strong, 2011).
•Grandparents need knowledge about available resources (Carr, Gray & Hayslip, 2012).
•Professionals working with older caregivers need to increase their knowledge of cultural diversity within this subgroup (Bertera & Crewe, 2013).
•Generally, elderly caregivers are unfamiliar with the public welfare system prior to assuming the role (Bertera & Crewe, 2013).

Implications for Social Workers

•Increase knowledge and skills with relative caregivers, especially around social policy mandates.
•Advocate for a consumer-friendly financial assistance application process.
•Attend to the dynamics of relative placement and work to diminish factors resulting in its instability.

Methods

Qualitative with a phenomenological perspective approach. Reporting of preliminary findings from a larger study (N=26).

Participants

- 10 female (7 European Americans and 3 African Americans).
- Ages 33-70, average, 57
- Length of caregiving ranged from 5-15 years.
- Caring for a range of 1-3 children (N=19).

Participant relationship to child

- Grandmother - 5 (50%)
- Great- Grandmother - 1 (1%)
- Great- Aunt - 2 (20%)
- Mix (First cousin and Grandmother and Aunt)- 2 (20%)

Recruitment

- Lutheran Social Services
- Interested caregivers called and were screened.

Eligibility Criteria

- Relative caregiver
- Caring for child under 18
- Biological parents were not living in the household.

Data Collection Procedures

- Telephone interviews were audiotaped and transcribed.
- Member checks were conducted.

Selected Interview Questions

- *How did placement occur?*
- *If Child Protection Services were involved, describe worker's initial approach?*
- *How was financial assistance obtained for the relative child?*
- *Are there other services that you need?*

Data Analysis

Constant comparative with open coding and selective coding.

Study Limitations

•Recruitment of caregivers who are not working with social service agencies may provide different perspectives.
•Conducting face-to-face interviews may offer richer stories and more detailed experiences.

Acknowledgements

A special thanks to Dr. Gibson for her outstanding mentorship and the entire McNair team for their amazing dedication and support.

Preliminary Findings

Financial Assistance

Receiving child-only grant:
No-6 (60%)
Yes-4 (40%)

Barriers to application process:
- Too stressful and lengthy
- Halted due to another person receiving benefits
- Unclear procedures

Financial stressors:
- Social Security denied for child with disabilities
- Accusation of fraud threatened receipt of benefits

Other financial assistance receiving:
- Adoption Assistance
- Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP)
- Child support from biological parents
- Social security benefits

Needed services:
- Social security for child with disabilities
- Support group for caregivers and children
- Respite care
- Knowledgeable social workers
- Senior housing services
- Legal assistance services
- Mental health services for children



Placement preferences

Placements status:
Formal-5 (50%)
Informal-5 (50%)

Initial placement after removal from parental care:
Relative placement-8 (80%)
Placed in foster care with stranger-2 (20%)

Child Protection Services (CPS) Involvement:
Yes-5 (50%)
No-5 (50%)

Reasons for placement:
- Drug abuse
- Incarceration
- Medical conditions
- Child maltreatment

Instability in placement:
Yes-6 (60%)
No-4 (40%)

Reasons for instability:
- Birth parent removes child from caregiver
- Mother kidnaps child
- Child Protection services removed child for previous child behavior assessment
- Biological mother resume parental role after incarceration

Biological parental contact:
- No contact-4 (40%)
- Frequent contact-4 (40%)
- Infrequent Contact-2 (20 %)

Available resources to caregivers:
- Birth parent helped with caring
- Child support from birth parent
- Private health insurance

Discussion

Financial Assistance



- Majority of caregivers in this study were not receiving child-only grant.
- When received, encountered problems during and after the application process.

Placement Preference

- Placement is dynamic despite relative placement preference in social policy.
- Most caregivers experienced placement instability; child being removed more then once by Child Protection Services (CPS) or biological parent.